

Accessibility

Today, inclusiveness has become very important and it is highly recommended that your website be accessible to those with special needs as well. Accessibility also happens to be one of the audits that Google runs for page ranking and must not be ignored.

The World Wide Web Consortium (W3C) has published a set of guidelines – the Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) that website designers must conform to, to ensure its accessibility. Following WCAG standards while developing the website also improves your SEO, because both rely on a semantic structure and functionality.

There are new opportunities and a lot of untapped potential in exploring this aspect. You can visit the accessibility guidelines at www.w3.org to get a list of all the W3C accessibility standards and best practices.

Domain age and URL

This is another factor that affects your page ranking. Don't take the literal meaning of 'age' in this case — it doesn't matter how long you may have owned a domain name. The domain age here is measured from that point of time when Google first saw a link to your domain and indexed it.

This is one of the reasons why some companies purchase aged domains. So, if you have been around for a couple of months, you will start showing up in the Google search results.

Even your URL's name has some contribution to your ranking. A well-crafted URL will give users as well as Google bots a clear understanding of what your website is about.

Quality backlinks

When one website links to another, this is called a backlink. Why are these important? Because having backlinks is like another website showing trust in your kind of site and vouching for it.

Backlinks are a validation of your website's quality from other, fellow websites out there. It is very important to have backlinks from highly popular and trustworthy websites. Similarly, linking out to other websites is also important, and the authority of your page is impacted by the type of websites you link out to.

This is impacted by:

1. The anchor text used
2. Whether you choose to follow or not follow
3. The other meta tags that you are using in the website

Content quality

One of the most important factors for ranking is high quality content. Google's own guidelines state that, "...high quality content is the single most important factor" for SEO. So, whenever a user asks Google a question, it has been designed to show the most accurate answer as the first result. Because even Google does not want users to go to some other search engine just because its first answer isn't the best. So, if your website's contents provide the best answers for a Google search query, your website will definitely be ranked higher among the results.

It is very important to keep the users from hitting the *Back* button and looking at other search results.

Don't just stop at providing the right answer, but make sure that the contents are presentable. (Just imagine that you have the best answer to a search query; however, it is hidden inside an accordion at the end of your Web page. Would the user be able to find it?) We can say that quality content increases search ranking which in turn leads to increased traffic for your website, and eventually leads to an increase in the conversion rate.

Social signals

An indirect factor that will boost your website's ranking is social media presence and status. The more people share your link on different social media platforms, the more trustworthy your

website is viewed as. As more people visit the website, they start linking to your page, which overall improves your website's authority. Combine all this with an awesome website, and Google will definitely notice and start listing you higher on the search results.

For this reason, it's important to make it easy to share your content.

- Amplify your social status.
- Run campaigns on social media platforms.
- Consider guest blogging (write blogs on other high authority websites and backlink the traffic to your website).

The user experience

We spoke of this a little when we touched upon having quality content and making it more presentable. Digging a little deeper, the way a person uses your website, and interacts and navigates through it, sums up that person's 'user experience' 'and that is linked to an emotion that they feel'. Enhancing your website's user experience is quite easy. Always put yourself in the end user's shoes when looking at the website.

There are a few factors to consider while designing your website:

1. Important information should always be above the fold.
2. Include contact information (a lot of people will drop out of your website if they don't find contact information).
3. Include clear and concise headings on all the pages.
4. Manage those ads (don't let them cover the content).
5. Include videos but don't auto-play unless necessary.
6. Provide your data through images instead of just text, tables and statistics.
7. The A/B test has new features as well as an update of the current user experience; see how it affects your conversion and implement it accordingly.